

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – HARVEST HYMN

by
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About the Poem

"Harvest Hymn" is a short satirical poem by John Betjeman, written in the style and metre of a traditional harvest hymn (such as "We Plough the Fields and Scatter") in order to mock that very tradition. Where a genuine harvest hymn gives thanks to God for the land and its natural bounty, Betjeman's poem is spoken in the voice of modern, profit-driven farmers who boast instead about poisoning wildflowers, burning hedgerows, and putting personal wealth before the land and its history.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*We spray the fields and scatter
The poison on the ground
So that no wicked wild flowers
Upon our farm are found.*

Paraphrasing:

The speakers (modern industrial farmers) openly admit to spraying chemical poison across their fields, deliberately killing off wildflowers, which they sarcastically call "wicked" – mimicking the language of a hymn while describing an act of environmental destruction.

Stanza 2:

*We like whatever helps us
To line our purse with pence;
The twenty-four-hour broiler house
And neat electric fence.*

Paraphrasing:

The farmers declare that they value anything that increases their profit, including intensive, round-the-clock "broiler houses" (factory farms for poultry) and electric fences – efficient, modern methods that prioritise money over the welfare of animals or the land.

Stanza 3:

*All concrete sheds around us
And Jaguars in the yard,
The telly lounge and deep-freeze
Are ours from working hard.*

Paraphrasing:

The farmers proudly list the material rewards of their modern, industrialised farming – concrete sheds, expensive Jaguar cars, a television lounge, and a deep-freeze – presenting these consumer comforts as the well-earned fruits of "working hard," in place of any spiritual or natural blessing.

Stanza 4:

*We fire the fields for harvest,
The hedges swell the flame,
The oak trees and the cottages
From which our fathers came.*

Paraphrasing:

The farmers describe burning the fields after harvest, a fire so large that it consumes not only the hedges but even old oak trees and the cottages associated with their own ancestors – showing a reckless destruction of both nature and family history for the sake of efficiency.

Stanza 5:

*We give no compensation,
The earth is ours today,
And if we lose of arable,
Then bungalows will pay.*

Paraphrasing:

The farmers declare that they owe nothing to anyone for the damage caused, claiming outright ownership of the land in the present moment; and if farmland is lost, they are unconcerned, since selling it for housing developments (“bungalows”) will bring in money instead.

Rhyming Scheme

The poem is written in five quatrains following a regular ABCB rhyme scheme (only the second and fourth lines of each stanza rhyme), in the same simple, singable ballad metre used by traditional hymns such as “We Plough the Fields and Scatter.” The poem's final line, “All concrete sheds... etc.,” signals that the third stanza is meant to be repeated as a refrain, exactly as a hymn's chorus would return after every verse – reinforcing the poem's parody of hymn form.

Theme

“Harvest Hymn” satirises the greed and environmental destructiveness of modern industrial farming, contrasting it with the reverence and gratitude toward nature found in traditional harvest hymns. By putting boastful, self-interested words into the mouths of “modern” farmers, Betjeman critiques the pursuit of profit and material comfort at the expense of wildlife, land, tradition, and community – a warning about the human cost of unchecked agricultural industrialisation.

Figures of Speech

• Parody

The entire poem imitates the structure, tone and metre of a traditional harvest hymn, using that familiar, reverent form to deliver a bitterly ironic message.

- **Irony**

Wildflowers are sarcastically called “wicked,” and material comforts (Jaguars, deep-freezes) are treated as blessings “from working hard” in place of any genuine gratitude to nature or God.

- **Satire**

The poem mocks the greed and environmental carelessness of modern intensive farming by having the farmers themselves proudly confess to it in hymn-like language.

- **Refrain**

The instruction “All concrete sheds... etc.” at the end shows that the third stanza functions as a repeated chorus, just as in a real hymn.

- **Symbolism**

The burning oak trees and ancestral cottages symbolise the destruction of natural and family heritage in the pursuit of profit.

- **Juxtaposition**

Sacred hymn form is juxtaposed with distinctly unsacred, materialistic content (poison, profit, cars, deep-freezes), creating the poem's central satirical effect.

Questions & Answers

Q1. What traditional form does “Harvest Hymn” imitate, and why?

It imitates the form and metre of a traditional harvest hymn, using that reverent, familiar structure ironically to criticise modern industrial farming instead of praising nature.

Q2. What do the farmers do to the wildflowers, and how do they describe them?

They spray poison to destroy wildflowers, sarcastically calling them “wicked” as if they were something sinful that needed to be eliminated.

Q3. What material rewards do the farmers boast about?

Concrete sheds, Jaguar cars, a television lounge, and a deep-freeze, which they credit to “working hard” rather than to nature's bounty.

Q4. What is destroyed when the farmers “fire the fields for harvest”?

The flames consume not just the hedges but also old oak trees and cottages linked to the farmers' own ancestors, showing careless destruction of nature and heritage alike.

Q5. What attitude do the farmers show toward the land and compensation in the final stanza?

They claim the land is entirely theirs “today,” refuse to pay any compensation for the damage caused, and are happy to sell farmland for housing if it proves more profitable.

Q6. What is the effect of ending the poem with “All concrete sheds... etc.”?

It signals that the third stanza is meant to repeat as a refrain, just like a hymn's chorus, reinforcing the poem's parody of religious harvest hymns.

Q7. What is the central theme of the poem?

It satirises the greed and environmental destructiveness of modern industrial farming, contrasting profit-driven values with the gratitude and reverence for nature found in genuine harvest hymns.